

GRE Vocabulary Notes: Group 17

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1. Acclaim

Meaning: Public praise or approval.

Tip to remember: Think of a crowd clapping and claiming someone is great. That is acclaim.

Sentence: The young researcher received acclaim for his innovative paper.

2. Ascertain

Meaning: To find out or confirm something with certainty.

Tip to remember: Ascertain contains “certain.” To ascertain is to make something certain.

Sentence: The engineer tested the circuit to ascertain the cause of failure.

3. Assertive

Meaning: Confident and direct in expressing opinions or needs.

Tip to remember: Assertive comes from assert, meaning to state strongly. An assertive person speaks clearly and confidently.

Sentence: She was assertive during the interview and explained her goals clearly.

4. Bogus

Meaning: Fake, false, or not genuine.

Tip to remember: Bogus sounds like “fake bonus.” A bogus offer looks good but is fake.

Sentence: The website was selling bogus certificates.

5. Cataclysmic

Meaning: Extremely destructive or disastrous.

Tip to remember: Think of a massive earthquake or flood changing everything. That event is cataclysmic.

Sentence: The cataclysmic earthquake destroyed many homes.

6. Circumscribe

Meaning: To limit, restrict, or draw a boundary around something.

Tip to remember: “Circum” means around, and “scribe” means write or draw. Circumscribe means to draw limits around something.

Sentence: The new rules circumscribed the power of the committee.

7. **Complementary**
Meaning: Combining well with something else; completing or improving another thing.
Tip to remember: Complementary comes from complete. Complementary skills complete each other.
Sentence: Solar and battery storage are complementary technologies.
8. **Contentious**
Meaning: Likely to cause disagreement or argument.
Tip to remember: Contentious sounds like contest. A contentious issue creates a contest of opinions.
Sentence: The land ownership issue was highly contentious.
9. **Disingenuous**
Meaning: Not honest or sincere; pretending to be innocent.
Tip to remember: Ingenuous means innocent and honest; disingenuous means not genuinely honest.
Sentence: His apology sounded disingenuous because he repeated the same mistake.
10. **Divulge**
Meaning: To reveal or make secret information known.
Tip to remember: Divulge sounds like “the vault.” When you open the vault, secrets come out.
Sentence: The employee refused to divulge confidential company data.
11. **Dogmatic**
Meaning: Strongly stating opinions as if they are facts and refusing to consider others’ views.
Tip to remember: Think of someone saying, “My belief is final.” That person is dogmatic.
Sentence: The dogmatic leader ignored all opposing evidence.
12. **Fallacious**
Meaning: Based on false reasoning or a mistaken belief.
Tip to remember: Fallacious contains “fallacy,” which means an error in reasoning.
Sentence: The argument was fallacious because it confused correlation with causation.
13. **Foolhardy**
Meaning: Recklessly brave or foolishly risky.
Tip to remember: The word itself says “fool” plus “hardy.” A foolhardy person acts brave like a fool.
Sentence: It was foolhardy to climb the mountain without proper equipment.
14. **Hinder**
Meaning: To slow down, delay, or obstruct progress.
Tip to remember: Hinder sounds like “behind.” If something hinders you, it keeps you behind.
Sentence: Poor time management can hinder GRE preparation.

15. **Impair**
Meaning: To weaken, damage, or reduce the quality of something.
Tip to remember: Impair sounds like “in bad repair.” If something is impaired, it is damaged.
Sentence: Lack of sleep can impair concentration.
16. **Impugn**
Meaning: To attack or question the truth, honesty, or character of someone.
Tip to remember: Impugn sounds like “I punch.” To impugn someone’s honesty is to punch their reputation verbally.
Sentence: The lawyer tried to impugn the witness’s credibility.
17. **Incessant**
Meaning: Continuing without stopping.
Tip to remember: “Cease” means stop. Incessant means not ceasing, or not stopping.
Sentence: The incessant noise from traffic made it hard to study.
18. **Inclined**
Meaning: Likely or willing to do something; having a tendency.
Tip to remember: Think of a slope leaning toward one side. If you are inclined to do something, your mind leans toward it.
Sentence: He is inclined to choose research over industry work.
19. **Inveterate**
Meaning: Having a long-established habit that is unlikely to change.
Tip to remember: Think of a veteran habit, old and deeply rooted. That is inveterate.
Sentence: He is an inveterate coffee drinker who never starts work without coffee.
20. **Miserly**
Meaning: Extremely unwilling to spend money; stingy.
Tip to remember: Miserly comes from miser, a person who hoards money.
Sentence: The miserly owner refused to repair the broken equipment.
21. **Patent**
Meaning: Obvious, clear, or easily seen.
Tip to remember: On the GRE, patent often means obvious, not only legal ownership of an invention.
Sentence: It was patent that the data had been manipulated.
22. **Petulant**
Meaning: Childishly angry or bad-tempered.
Tip to remember: Think of a child pouting when denied a toy. That child is petulant.
Sentence: His petulant response made the discussion unprofessional.
23. **Pithy**
Meaning: Short but full of meaning.

Tip to remember: Think of a tiny seed with strong life inside. A pithy sentence is small but powerful.

Sentence: The professor gave a pithy explanation of the theory.

24. **Pliant**

Meaning: Easily bent, flexible, or easily influenced.

Tip to remember: Pliant sounds like “plastic.” Both can bend easily.

Sentence: The material is pliant enough to be shaped by hand.

25. **Sanctimonious**

Meaning: Pretending to be morally superior to others.

Tip to remember: Sanctimonious sounds like “saint-like.” A sanctimonious person acts like a fake saint.

Sentence: His sanctimonious lecture annoyed the students.

26. **Sound**

Meaning: Reliable, logical, and based on good judgment.

Tip to remember: A sound bridge is strong; a sound argument is also strong.

Sentence: Her conclusion was based on sound evidence.

27. **Tarnish**

Meaning: To damage the reputation, brightness, or quality of something.

Tip to remember: Silver tarnishes and loses shine; a scandal can tarnish a reputation.

Sentence: The corruption case tarnished the leader’s image.

28. **Tepid**

Meaning: Lukewarm; lacking enthusiasm.

Tip to remember: Think of tea that is neither hot nor cold. Tepid support is also weak and lukewarm.

Sentence: The proposal received only a tepid response from investors.

29. **Upbraid**

Meaning: To scold or criticize severely.

Tip to remember: Think of someone raising their voice “up” to scold you. That is upbraiding.

Sentence: The coach upbraided the players for their lack of discipline.

30. **Vexation**

Meaning: Annoyance, frustration, or irritation.

Tip to remember: Vex means annoy. Vexation is the feeling of being vexed.

Sentence: The repeated software errors caused great vexation among the users.